

CONCORD AND COLLOCATION

The word 'concord' simply means agreement or harmony. It is the agreement which must exist between the subject of a sentence; whether a noun, noun phrase or pronoun, and the verb. The rule of concord is that singular subject must be followed by a singular verb while a plural subject must be followed by a plural verb. Talking about singular and plural subjects or nouns and singular and plural verbs, it is important to state here that plural nouns can be recognised by the addition of 's', 'es', 'ies' to them. Conversely, verbs that have these letters added to them are in the singular form, not plural. This is the first step towards students' mastery of concord. Consider the illustration below:

DIFFERENT APPLICATIONS OF CONCORD

(1) Any time either or /neither nor correlates two subjects, the verb to use will be determined by the subject nearest to the verb, that is, the subject that immediately follows nor/or. Let us take a look at the following sentences:

(i) Either James or you are sick (correct).

Either James or you is sick (wrong).

(ii) Either Udoh or the boys are foolish (correct).

Either Udoh or the boys is foolish (wrong).

(2) When a percentage or fraction is the subject of a sentence, followed by of, it is the noun or pronoun that follows the percentage or fraction that determines the verb to use, not the percentage or fraction. If the percentage or fraction is singular, then a singular verb follows, and vice versa.

(i) Three quarters of the students have packed in (correct)

Three quarters of the students has packed in (wrong).

(ii). Sixty per cent of the class is absent (correct).



Sixty per cent of the class are absent (wrong).

(3) Many a or many an must be followed by a singular noun in a sentence, followed also by a singular verb:

Many a/an + singular noun + singular verb.

(i) Many a student does not read anymore (correct).

Many a student do not read anymore (wrong).

(ii) Many an egg has been eaten today (correct).

Many an egg have been eaten today (wrong).

(iii) Many a preacher has died lately (correct).

Many a preacher have died lately (wrong).

(4) Anytime the word number is the subject of a sentence and is followed by of, it takes a plural verb if number is preceded by the indefinite articles a, and a singular verb if preceded by the definite article the. Eg:

(i) A number of students have been arrested (correct).

A number of students has been arrested (wrong).

(ii) The number of students is not known (correct).

The number of students are not known (wrong).

(5). A plural noun which is the subject of a sentence will take a singular verb if it is referring to time, distance, money or measurement Plural nouns relating to time include seconds, minutes, hours, days, weeks, months, years, etc. Plural nouns relating to distance include metres, kilometers, miles, etc. Plural nouns relating to money include dollars, naira, shilling, pounds, etc. while plural nouns relating to measurement include grammes, kilogrammes, yards, litres, etc. Examples:

(i) Ten minutes was allocated to prayers (correct).



Ten minutes were allocated to prayers (wrong).

(ii) Ten yards of lace material is just enough (correct).

Ten yards of lace material are just enough (wrong).

(iii) Ten kilometres of trekking needs to be done (correct).

Ten kilometres of trekking need to be done (wrong).

(iv) Ten million naira is needed for his trip (correct).

Ten million naira are needed for his trip (wrong).

6. Any time any of the collectives is used as the subject of a sentence, it must go with a plural noun followed by a singular verb. Examples:

(i) A battalion of soldiers has moved to Kano (correct).

A battalion of soldiers have moved to Kano (wrong).

(ii) A troupe of dancers is needed for the ceremony (correct).

A troupe of dancers are needed for the ceremony (wrong).

(iii) A swarm of locusts has been sighted from afar (correct).

A swarm of locusts have been sighted from afar (wrong).

(iv) A flock of sheep has invaded his farm (correct).

A flock of sheep have invaded his farm (wrong).

When a collective name is used to denote a category (of people), it goes with a plural verb. Examples:

(i) The rich also cry (correct).

The rich also cries (wrong).

(ii) The blind need assistance (correct).

The blind needs assistance (wrong).

(iii) The poor always feel cheated (correct).

The poor always feels cheated (wrong).

8. A collective noun may take a singular or plural verb depending on the notion

one has in mind. When a collective noun is seen as an entity, it takes a singular verb but when it is seen from the angle of the individual items that constituted the entity, it takes a plural verb. Again, a collective noun that is not performing any action takes a singular verb and a plural verb when it is performing an action. Examples:

(i) The police are searching for criminals (correct).

The police is searching for criminals (wrong).

(The action here is 'searching')

(ii) The police is your friend (correct).

The police are your friend (wrong).

(Police' here is an entity)

(iii) The audience is too large (correct).

The audience are too large (wrong).

('Audience' not performing any action).

9. When all means 'everything' it takes a singular verb but when it refers to a collection of people or actions, it takes a plural verb. Examples:

(i) All want to travel abroad (correct).

All wants to travel abroad (wrong).

(All' here refers to people)

(ii) All is set for the inauguration (correct).

All are set for the inauguration (wrong).

(All' here refers to everything)

(iii) All that glitters is not gold (correct).

All that glitters are not gold (wrong).

(All' above means everything)



(iv) All is not well here (correct).

All are not well here (wrong).

(All' here also means everything)

(v) All have agreed to pay promptly (correct).

All has agreed to pay promptly (wrong).

(All' here refers to a collection of people).

10. When a singular number or noun follows 'every' or 'each' as is always the case, a singular verb is used. Examples:

(i) Every man wants to be the boss (correct).

Every man want to be the boss (wrong).

(ii) Each biro costs ten naira (correct).

Each biro cost ten naira (wrong).

However, when every or each is used in a sentence and a coordinator and links two or more subjects, a singular verb is used.

(i) Every pastor, deacon and elder needs to attend (correct).

Every pastor, deacon and elder need to attend (wrong).

(ii) Every boy and girl knows the reason (correct).

Every boy and girl know the reason (wrong).

Again, each of and everyone of must be followed by a plural number and a singular verb: Examples:

(i) Each of the boys has a friend (correct).

Each of the boys have a friend (wrong).

(ii) Everyone of the members was fined for lateness (correct).

Everyone of the members were fined for lateness (wrong).

